

St Peter's Basilica

St Peter's in Rome stands on a site venerated since the first century CE as the burial place of Peter the Apostle. In 326, the emperor Constantine built an opulent church on the site which served for over 1,100 years. In the 16th century, Pope Julius II (1443–1513) commissioned from Donato Bramante a new church for the site and the adjacent Vatican Palace. The design was in a Greek cross format, with four small domes on each extension and a huge central dome, rising to a height of 136.5 metres (448 ft), raised on four huge piers. The construction would take 120 years (1506–1626) and undergo radical changes under a succession of designers. After Bramante died in 1514, Raphael (1483–1520) took over, succeeded after his death by Baldassare Peruzzi (1481–1536), then Antonio da Sangallo (1485–1546). After him, Michelangelo (1475–1564), at age 72, reluctantly took on the job, drawing the design into a cohesive unity that was largely preserved after his death by the final architect, Carlo Maderno (1556–1629), but for the late addition of a nave and a grand façade overlooking St Peter's Square.

